



Making a point: Left out of India's U-19 probables in 2024, Ayush Mhatre forced his way in with a 2024-25 season too loud to ignore and ended up wearing the captain's armband. GETTY IMAGES

THE HARD PART STARTS NOW

The U-19 World Cup is an audition, not a destination. History shows why the **next step**, into senior cricket, is the toughest.

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The ICC Under-19 World Cup is often a defining stop on the road to the national team. For many, it is the first real audition for higher honours.

For one, the U-19 World Cup is a test of one's wares against the world's best. It is also a youngster's first brush with playing under the

limelight, which often brings pressure and scrutiny along with it. A good tournament can put a player on the map. A poor one can do the opposite.

India has made the best use of this pathway. The Ayush Mhatre-led side, which beat England in the final this month, became the sixth Indian team to win the title. Since 2016,

India hasn't finished below second.

Yuvraj Singh, Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli, Ravindra Jadeja, K.L. Rahul and Shubman Gill all passed through this level.

Reetinder Sodhi, who played two U-19 World Cups (1998 and 2000), credits the BCCI's system for consistently producing talent. "The infrastructure makes a lot of